DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Are You Standing in the Light?

Derech Hashem 2:8:2-3

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 8, paragraphs 2-3 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 26 August 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: don't spray the mouldy apples

Chapter 8 is the last chapter of the part on providence, and it deals with a few separate points. On Monday the Rabbi taught the first: everything learned about reward and punishment works through the lens of mishpat, the system Hashem created, in which He has, as it were, bound Himself to its rules. But at times He acts with the hashgahah of His sole authority (hanhagat hayihud), setting the rules aside because He loves His children. That is what Rosh Hashanah is about. The Ramhal does not say so here, but he develops it in a short essay on Rosh Hashanah, which the Rabbi recommended and offered to send to the group.

The first day of Rosh Hashanah is harsh judgement and the second soft judgement; by the second day we want no din at all. Praying on Rosh Hashanah for livelihood or health, he said, is like having a beautiful tree with some mouldy apples and spraying pesticide on the apples. Look instead at the roots and the bark, to see why it is producing mouldy apples. Focus on the bigger picture: Hashem is King and in control, and may He suspend the din. Once that is done, everything else falls into place.

Paragraph 2: influence on body and on soul

"Umimah shesarikh shetedah od": Hashem's influence (hashpaah) is also of two kinds, one for the body (guf) and one for the soul (nefesh). Everything in the last chapters about why people suffer or prosper, have tranquillity or not, concerns the physical side of our identity. But there is also influence on the soul: on a person's intellect and understanding, his closeness to Hashem, and his spiritual qualities.

The Ramhal then describes two extremes. The first is a utopia: "If you were God, how would you want this world to look?" - all humanity cleaving to wisdom and busy with serving Hashem; - truth clearly visible, wickedness subdued, deceit cast away; - only one service of God, and no other; - every good trait strengthened and every bad trait rejected.

Corresponding to that, the influence on the body would be peace and tranquillity, without suffering. Hashem would openly reveal His glory in the world and rejoice in His creatures, and they would rejoice to serve Him.

The other extreme is the exact opposite: people neglecting their souls entirely and pursuing their physical drives; rejecting wisdom; little or no service of Hashem; truth thrown to the ground; wickedness growing and succeeding; trickery and deceit; many strange forms of worship; good traits eclipsed and bad ones everywhere. Correspondingly there would be no tranquillity and much suffering. Hashem would hide His glory, and the world would seem left to chance, "as if there is no director of this world." Hashem would not rejoice in His creatures, nor they in Him.

What the Rabbi drew from it

The point, he said, is that everything learned about Hashem's influence on our health, wealth and relationships applies equally to spiritual things. Hashem also gives to the soul: wisdom, understanding, the qualities of character. How much will you be able to understand Torah? How much will you be able to understand Hashem? That too is part of His influence, and if you work on it, He gives in that area too. And the two are linked: if everyone worked on their character and on truth, it would have a knock-on effect on the physical world, and the reverse.

A participant remarked that these sound like the descriptions of the period before and after Mashiah. The Rabbi agreed in part: the Gemara's description of the generation before Mashiah is what the world will look like when it reaches the point of no return, though behaving that way will not bring it. Our world is nowhere near either extreme. A pessimist would say we are closer to the second, an optimist to the first. We have progressed a great deal intellectually, and in caring for children in poverty and in rights for women; in other ways we have gone far backwards. "No one knows exactly what the status of the world is."

Another participant suggested that Monday's idea, Hashem suspending din, could explain why the wicked prosper. The Rabbi called it a good point but limited: it can only explain wicked people prospering, not righteous people suffering, and only for short periods, not a whole lifetime. "Which is why I probably never offered this." Still, it adds an element of explanation.

Paragraph 3: we live in the court of the body

"Vehineh kevar nitbaer bihelek alef perek dalet": as explained in Part 1, Chapter 4 (which the Rabbi had quoted in his Tuesday night shiur), the default state of a person in this world is that materialism is rooted in him.

He gave an image. Think of a tennis court: one half is the body, the other half the soul, with the net between them. You might think we are poised on the net, the body pulling us down and the soul lifting us up. In fact we are standing in the court of the body, because we live in a physical world. But joined into our physical nature is an illumination from which understanding comes. A baby is born without knowledge and without reason, and as the child grows his intellect grows.

The beam of light

The key line: the root of it all is the illumination or the concealment of Hashem's light, as explained in Part 1. "This is the source of all good and bad. Are you in the beam or are you not in the beam?" The Rabbi contrasted this with the dualism of other religions, children of light

against children of darkness. Here the light is always shining; the question is whether you have put yourself into the beam or taken yourself out of it.

As much illumination as Hashem gives, that much value and clarity follow; from concealment come deficiency, opaqueness and worthlessness. And since every human being is a mixture of advantages and deficiencies, clarity and opaqueness, every influence we receive is also a mixture. "It's not just black and white... Very rarely are you totally in the beam or totally out of the beam. What's normally happening is we're in and out of the beam." This begins above and comes down here, and from this mixture comes all the good and bad for both body and soul.

On Monday the chapter will be finished, with the stages of humanity, and then Chapter 7, on astrology, before Rosh Hashanah.

Summary

- On Rosh Hashanah, focus on the root, Hashem's kingship and the suspension of din, not on the individual "mouldy apples" of personal requests.
- Paragraph 2: Hashem's influence is on the soul as well as the body: wisdom, closeness to Him, character.
- The Ramhal contrasts a world devoted to wisdom and truth, filled with peace and Divine revelation, with a world of materialism and deceit, where Hashem seems absent; our world lies between.
- Paragraph 3: we stand in the "court" of the body, with an illumination joined to us.
- All good and bad flow from how much we stand in the beam of Hashem's light, and most of us are in and out of it.

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